

speculations concerning God and divine beings (*Hypostases*¹ = Amesha Spenta); in both, sacrifice and worship (*Kult*) recedes before ritual and ceremonial, and we may characterise both as religions of observance (of the Law). In both great stress is laid on the care of the poor. Just as the order of Scribes arose in Judaism over against the priesthood, the Magi among the Persians gained increasingly the character of theologians, commentators, and custodians of an ancient scripture tradition. Just as a canon of Scripture was formed in later Judaism, Parsism appears in the same period to have possessed a like collection. True, in all this there need not be any dependence: it may all be parallel development. But the coincidence in so many points is extremely remarkable, and compels us to examine it more closely. For we are concerned here with contacts and perhaps with dependence in the very centre of things.

One more quotation may be in place before I proceed to elaborate the parallel. Prof. Söderblom, at the beginning of his important work, *Les Fravashis*, quotes a late Parsi creed according to the translation of Darmesteter. It runs thus:

I have no doubt as to the truth of the good religion of the worshippers of Mazda, the coming of the Resurrection and the future life, the passing of the Cinvat Bridge, the account made during the Three Nights [after death] of merits and reward, of faults and punishment, the truth of heaven and hell, the annihilation of Ahriman and the demons, the final victory of God the Spirit of Good, and the destruction of the spirit of evil and the demons, the brood of darkness.

¹ A definition of these *hypostases* may be appended from Prof. Bertholet's continuation of Stade, *Bibl. Theol. des A. T.*, II. 394: they are "nicht ganz so anschaulich konkrete, volkstümliche Gestalten wie die Engel, aber auch nicht reine abstrakte Gedankengebilde; die naive Philosophie denkt sie sich in gewisser Weise persönlich" (W. Luekens, *Die Schriften des N. T.*, II. 335).